

Rs 5,000 crore then, the government has managed to issue only 12 lakh identity cards in the first phase of the pilot project. These should serve as the primary document to prove identity instead of a ration card, passport and others.

According to government sources, the project is stuck due to turf wars among the ministries of Information and Technology, Home and also the Election Commission. MNIC should be issued to all citizens within a fixed time frame. It should be the primary document to prove identity, instead of a ration card, passport, driving licence or PAN card.

The tardiness of the response of the police and security personnel were evident in the Mumbai attack. What is needed is urgent infusion of funds to beef up the existing po-

Action Plan

GET experts and career police officers, with experience in security and counter-

terrorism, to head crucial departments in the Home Ministry, including the top job of the Home Secretary

ACT on reports on police reforms and also implement multipurpose national identity cards

ENSURE co-ordination among intelligence agencies and send a clear message that a terror strike must be avoided at any cost or heads will roll

RED TAPE needs to be cut in making purchases for internal security

SACK top officials for negligence leading to terror strikes

SEGREGATE internal security from the other functions of the Home Ministry

Learning from the US

Mandate of the MHA

India's Ministry of Home Affairs has its finger in too many pies that make it highly unwieldy and ineffective against terror strikes.

Among the MHA's major tasks are law and order, police modernisation, border management, centre-state relations, official languages policy apart from Jammu and Kashmir, Northeast insurgency and Maoist Extremism.

In 2008 alone, there were 64 terror attacks across India.

US Homeland Security

In 2002, US President George Bush created a single, unified Department of Homeland Security to protect America.

The new department has only four divisions with a clear focus: border and transportation security, emergency preparedness and response, information analysis and infrastructure protection and counter measures against WMDs.

Since its formation, the US faced no major terror strike.

lice forces. The MHA had set aside Rs 1,300 crore for the modernisation of state police forces in 2008-09, an amount that has nearly doubled over the past five years. This money is meant to be spent on better mobility, modern weaponry, communication system, training, infrastructure facilities, forensic science facilities, strengthening of intelligence branches, security equipment, construction of buildings of police stations, and construction of residential buildings for lower level police personnel.

The problem is that there is no accountability on part of the states or, for that matter, the Centre. There is no system of a follow-up or to check what the states are doing with the funds. The MHA should have an annual audit whereby senior officers personally visit the states to see and inspect how the states have used their modernisation funds. This would also introduce accountability at the level of various secretaries and joint secretaries of the Ministry.

A foolproof system of fixing

responsibility needs be put in place. The response of agencies and officials after the Mumbai terror attacks was typical—passing the buck among various agencies starting from the IB and R&AW to Navy and the Coast Guard. Till date it is still not certain who goofed up where. By now, accountability should have been fixed and some heads rolled. Ideally, there should have been a time-bound Commission of Inquiry—much like what the US did following 9/11—to probe what went wrong and why the attack could not be prevented. Also, what measures need to be taken to prevent such attacks.

Not sparing anybody, the commission should push for action against officials who were slack in performing their duty. This would cover all agencies including the IB, R&AW, Maharashtra Police, Navy and the Coast Guard. Even politicians should be called in, if need be. Unless tough action is taken, the MHA will lurch from crisis to crisis and the Indian state would suffer.